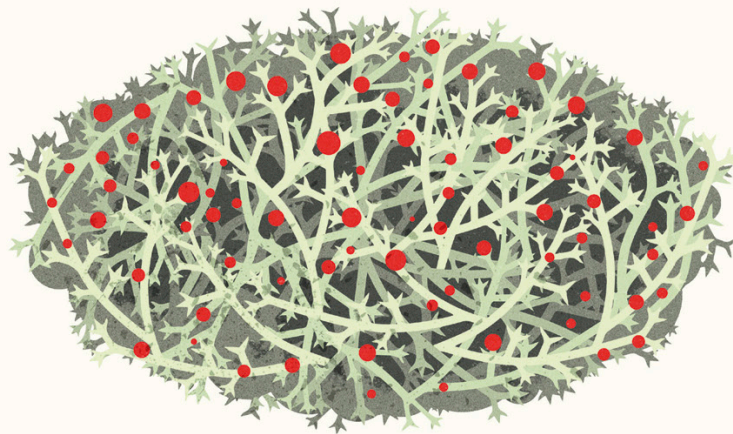


Lichen

Sometimes life is all about sharing, and it's what lichens (lie-kens) do best. A lichen is two different organisms, living in the same body. One is a fungus, and inside it is a green alga. The fungus keeps the alga safe and shares water with it. The alga makes food from sunlight to share with the fungus. Both end up as winners!

Where it is too tough for plants, you find lichens. They don't need soil, so you often see them on rocks, walls, or roofs. They can be found close to the South Pole and in the Arctic. To reproduce, lichens make blobs of dust-like spores, which spread like seeds to grow new lichens. Reindeer lichen makes spores in bright-red spots.



Silvery-grey reindeer lichen is an important food for reindeer in the winter.